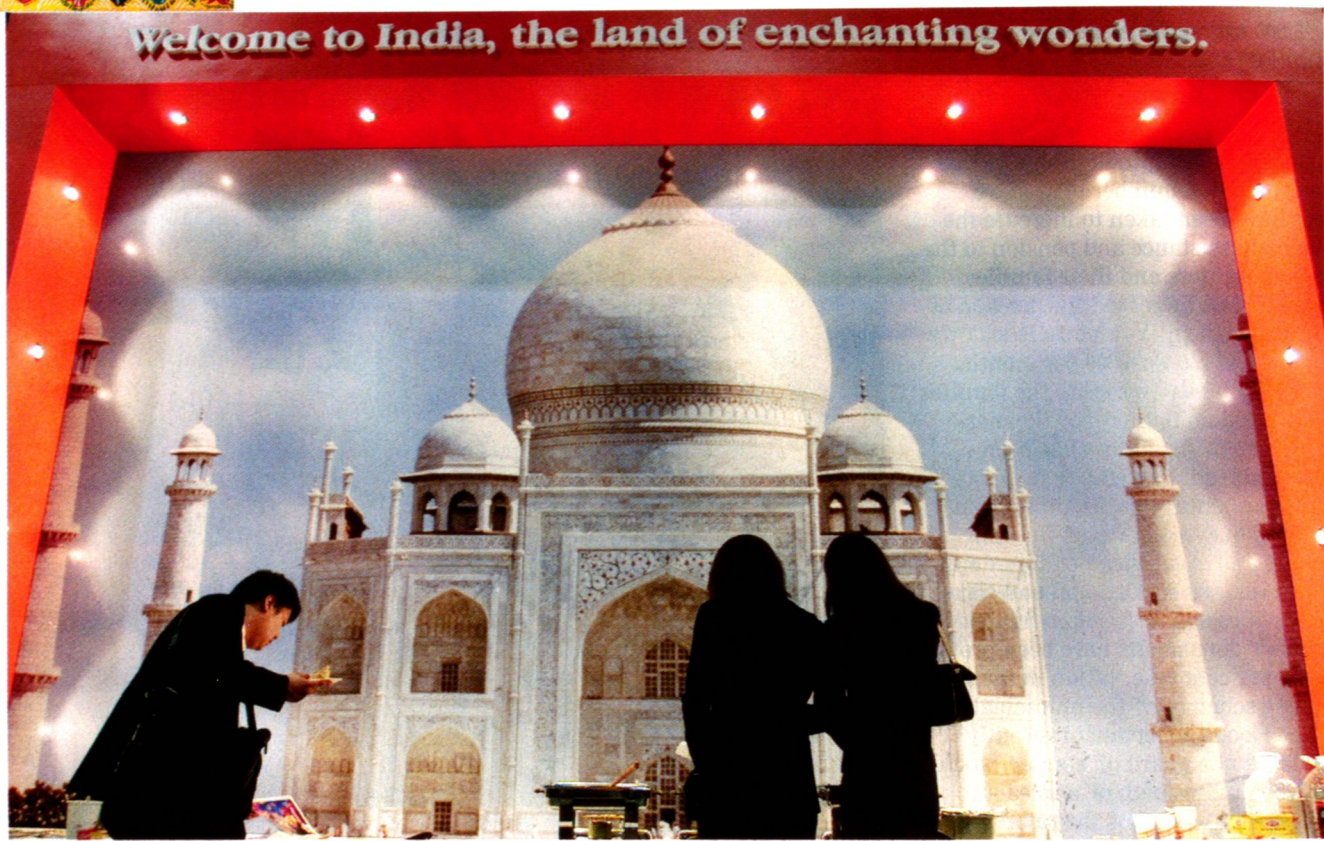




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No More HOLIDAYS IN HELL

Improved infrastructure and communication are crucial for making India a leader in tourism

— By **AMITABH KANT**

Tourism has emerged as a major industry in Asia, creating employment and stimulating economic development over the last 50 years. Nearly 8 per cent of global employment is tourism-dependent. The latest study by the World Travel and Tourism Council demonstrates that between 2008 and 2018 the highest annualised real growth of travel and tourism demand worldwide, at 9.4 per cent, will occur in India. To mine this potential for further growth, we need to focus on infrastructure, develop niche sectors and open up new areas of growth. A critical constraint

in tourism expansion is our lack of quality experience on the ground. Although India's USP is its matchless heritage sites, on the ground there is shockingly poor sanitation and safety. These tourism infrastructure deficiencies can derail India's thrust to become a world-class global destination. So tourism has to become everyone's concern. The "Incredible India" branding cannot be isolated from the ground reality. Essentially, a brand is what a brand does. The campaign cannot be sustained if the quality of experience offered to tourists does not remain credible. Infrastructure development and destination management, therefore, hold the key to India's sustained growth in the tourism sector.

Another critical issue is hotel accommodation. We need more hotels, particularly budget